India that would decrease the adverse impact of Chinese actions on opinion there. It expected Delhi to need help with the refugees, but it told officials to wait for Indian requests for that aid.[61] Subsequently, the administration also took care not to highlight the US government's assistance.[62] Defense Secretary Neil H. McElroy wanted more efforts to publicize the Chinese crackdown, but Secretary of State Christian Herter advised caution.[63] The US instead tried to get Taiwan to give up its claim to Tibet publicly and recognize Tibetan independence. Jiang had pledged to recognize Tibetans' right to self-determination, but Assistant Secretary of State for Far Eastern Affairs Walter S. Robertson thought that was insufficient.[64]

India's actions also fell short of what the US would have liked. In addition, there were concerns about India's position on the Dalai Lama. The Taiwanese ambassador told Robertson that Nehru would force the Tibetan leader to return—which the US knew was a Chinese demand[65]—in exchange for a Sino-Indian border settlement.[66] Dillon worried that the Dalai Lama, on his part, would take hasty public action that would put Washington in a bind. He had already called for the US to recognize a Tibetan government and persuade others to do so as well.[67]

There were inter- and intra-agency differences on recognition. The Near East and International Organization bureaus at the State Department were more cautious. The Far East bureau argued that, if other countries did so, the US should recognize a Tibetan government. It stressed that the views of India and other nonaligned countries should not be decisive.[68] Members of the Joint Chiefs of Staff also hoped that the US could be more proactive, but Deputy Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs Robert D. Murphy cautioned against moves that could make Tibet be seen as a Cold War issue —that might give Nehru an excuse to "wash his hands of the matter."[69] At a subsequent National Security Council (NSC) meeting, National Security Adviser Gray noted the Defense Department's call for the "hands off" policy to be re-examined, but Eisenhower wanted the State Department, which remained cautious, to keep the lead.[70]

American officials did not want Delhi to have a veto on Washington's Tibet policy. Nonetheless, India's role and the US-India relationship made its opinion an "important factor."[71] There was understanding as well as concern about Delhi's caution. In an NSC meeting, Allen Dulles explained Nehru's dual problem of needing to "conciliate China," as well as